

文 法 Grammar

1 Past Tense Short Forms

Here we will learn the past tense paradigm of short forms. With four parts of speech and two polarities, there are eight forms in the chart, but you need to learn only three rules.

- (1) Verbs: Replace the *te*-form endings て and で with た and だ.
 (2) い-adjectives: Replace the last い with かった. You may also think of this in terms of “dropping です from the long form.”
 (3) な-adjectives and nouns: Replace the long form でした ending with だった.
 Negation: ない conjugates as an い-adjective. Therefore, for all categories, you can replace the last ない with なかった.

Past, affirmative

• verbs:

食べた

読んだ

• い-adjectives:

かわいかった

• な-adjectives:

静かだった

• noun + です:

学生だった

compare with:

食べて

読んで

かわいい／かわいかったです

静かでした

学生でした

Past, negative

• verbs:

読まなかった

• い-adjectives:

かわいくなかった

• な-adjectives:

静かじゃなかった

• noun + です:

学生じゃなかった

読まない

かわいくない

静かじゃない

学生じゃない

2 Past Tense Short Forms in Informal Speech

Short form predicates in the past tense can be used in the same way as the present tense forms, which we discussed in Lesson 8. Note that the question particle か is dropped in informal speech.

A: けさ、朝ご飯を食べた？

Did you have breakfast this morning?

B: うん、食べた。／ううん、食べなかった。

Yes, I did. / No, I didn't.

Unlike だ in the present tense, だった is not dropped in informal speech.

A: 先週は忙しかった？
せんしゅう いそが

Were you busy last week?

B: ううん、忙しくなかった。ひまだった。 No, I wasn't. I had free time.
いそが

3 Past Tense Short Forms in Quoted Speech: ～と思います

As in the present tense, you use the short form in the past tense with ～と思います (I think) to report what you think took place in the past.

A: あ、私のとんかつがない！
わたし

Hey, my pork cutlet is gone!

B: トムさんが食べたと思います。
た おも

I think Tom ate it.

去年の冬はあまり寒くなかったと思います。
きょねん ふゆ さむ おも

I don't think last winter was very cold. (= I think last winter was not very cold.)

4 Past Tense Short Forms in Quoted Speech: ～と言っていました

If you heard somebody utter a sentence in the past tense, you can report it with the short form past tense with ～と言っていました。

ヤスミンさんは、昼ご飯を食べなかったと言っていました。
ひる はん た い

Yasmin said that she didn't have lunch.



ヤスミンさんは
昼ご飯を食べなかったと
ひる はん た
言っていました。

Note that Japanese does not have the “sequence of tense” rule, and the tense of the original utterance is preserved when it is reported. If you are reporting somebody’s utterance in which the present tense is used, you must also use the present tense inside the quote. Thus, if your friend Yasmin said 今、晩ご飯を食べています, using the present tense, your report will have 晩ご飯を食べている in the present tense, rather than 晩ご飯を食べていた in the past tense.

ヤスミンさんは晩ご飯を食べていると言っていました。

Yasmin said that she was having dinner.

5 Qualifying Nouns with Verbs and Adjectives

The following table shows various forms of noun modification. The phrases in the left qualify the noun 人 (person) to their right. Example 1 is a straightforward adjectival modification. Example 2 contains a phrase describing a person’s attribute (Lesson 7), and Example 3 has a な-adjective with a grammatical object (Lesson 5). Example 4 has a verb in the short form (Lesson 8).

e.g. 1.	<u>おもしろい</u>	人 ひと	a person <u>who is interesting</u>
e.g. 2.	<u>髪が長い</u>	人 ひと	a person <u>who has long hair</u>
e.g. 3.	<u>猫が好きな</u>	人 ひと	a person <u>who likes cats</u>
e.g. 4.	<u>めがねをかけている</u>	人 ひと	a person <u>who wears glasses</u>
	↑	↑	
	adjectives and verbs	noun	
	used as qualifiers		

Here we focus on a verb + ている, which is very frequently used as noun modifiers, describing people on the basis of their current actions and states.¹

A: ゆいさんはどの人ですか。 Which one is Yui?

B: あそこで本を読んでいる人です。 Yui is the one who is reading a book over there.

あそこで写真を撮っている学生はロバートさんです。

The student taking pictures over there is Robert.

¹ Short forms other than ている can also be used for noun modification, as in 毎日運動する人 (a person who exercises every day) and たばこをすわない人 (a person who does not smoke). We will explore a wider range of verb forms used in noun modification in Lesson 15.

6 もう～ました and まだ～ていません

You can use the affirmative past tense of a verb ～ました both (i) to talk about an event that happened at a certain time in the past (きのう *yesterday*, for example), just like *did* in English, and also (ii) to talk about a past event that still has an effect at present, just like *have done* in English (used with adverbs like もう *already*, for example).

(i) しゅくだい きのう宿題をしました。

I did the homework yesterday.

(ii) しゅくだい もう宿題をしました。

I have already done the homework.

With the negative, the past is used only to talk about a finished time period like きのう, but ている is used if your intention is to talk about how things stand now (“not yet”).

(i) しゅくだい きのう宿題をしませんでした。

I did not do the homework yesterday.

(ii) しゅくだい まだ宿題をしていません。

I have not done the homework yet.

もう～ました	<i>have already . . .</i>
まだ～ていません	<i>have not . . . yet</i>

会
L9

7 Explanation から、Situation

We learned in Lesson 6 that から added to a sentence means “because.”

朝ご飯を食べませんでした。忙しかったですから。
あさ はん た いそが

I didn't have breakfast. (Because) I was busy.

You can put these two sentences into one, by moving the “explanation + から” sequence to the beginning of a sentence for which the explanation is offered. The resulting order of elements resembles that of a “therefore” sentence more closely than that of a “because” sentence in English.

explanation から、 situation。 = situation , because explanation . = explanation ; therefore, situation .
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あした試験しけんがあるから、今晚勉強こんばんべんきょうします。

I will study this evening, because we will have an exam tomorrow.

(= We will have an exam tomorrow; therefore, I will study this evening.)

寒さむかったから、出でかけませんでした。

We didn't go out, because it was cold.

(= It was cold; therefore, we didn't go out.)

Before the conjunction から, you find both the long and short forms. Thus the から clauses in the above examples can be rewritten as あした試験しけんがありますから and 寒さむかったですから.² The long form before から is more polite, and is frequently found in request and suggestion sentences.

かぶきのチケットがありますから、一緒いっしょに見みに行きましよう。

Let's go to see Kabuki. I have tickets.

² The long form before から is inappropriate when the entire sentence ends in a short form, however. Thus it is inappropriate to say: ×寒さむかったですから、出でかけなかった。